PassFrame
TUITION

The King Who Burned the Cakes

Year 4 — 11+ Homework Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Non-fiction (History)

Extract — read it carefully before answering

More than a thousand years ago, England was threatened by fierce invaders called the Vikings. The king at the time was a clever and determined man named Alfred, who ruled the kingdom of Wessex. For a while, things went so badly for Alfred's army that he was forced into hiding in the marshes of Somerset, disguised as an ordinary traveller so that nobody would recognise him as a king.

One cold evening, tired and hungry, Alfred came to the small cottage of a peasant woman. Not knowing who her guest really was, she agreed to let him shelter by her fire, on one condition: he must watch her cakes while she went out to fetch water, and make sure they did not burn.

Alfred sat by the warm hearth, but his mind was far away, worrying about battles and strategies for defeating the Vikings. Before he knew it, smoke was curling up from the hearth — the cakes had burned black.

When the woman returned, she was furious. 'You lazy good-for-nothing!' she scolded, not realising she was shouting at her king. 'You were happy enough to eat them, but you couldn't be bothered to watch them!'

Alfred said nothing except a quiet apology. Not long afterwards, he gathered his strength, rallied his soldiers, and went on to defeat the Vikings in a great battle — proving that even a king can learn something from a burnt cake.

Questions

25 min · 12 questions

1. In which region was Alfred hiding?

2. What did the woman ask Alfred to do while she fetched water?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you Alfred eventually defeated the Vikings.

4. Underline the word the woman used to insult Alfred.

5. What does “rallied” mean in the sentence “he rallied his soldiers”?

6. Put these events in order: the cakes burn / Alfred defeats the Vikings / Alfred hides in the marshes / the woman scolds Alfred.

7. Why might Alfred have chosen the marshes of Somerset as a hiding place?

8. What job title does the text use for Alfred before we learn he was king?

9. Why do you think the woman “was furious” when she saw the burnt cakes?

10. What does the final sentence suggest the writer wants us to think about Alfred?

11. Find and copy a word that means “angrily told someone off”.

12. Do you think it was fair of the woman to scold a stranger the way she did? Explain your thinking.